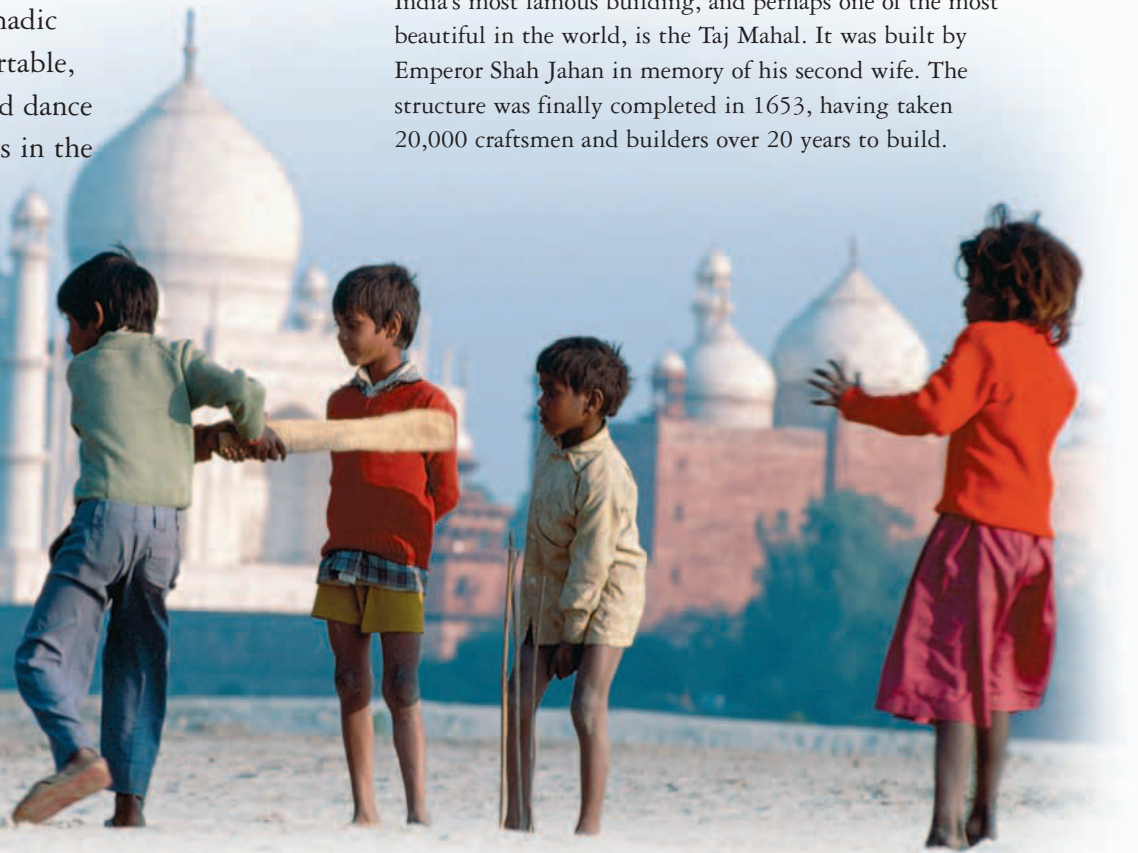




Art and culture

Where people have lived nomadic lives, their arts tend to be portable, so textiles, jewelry, music, and dance are the most notable art forms in the more mountainous reaches of central Asia. Wonderful examples of literature and architecture have been and continue to be produced in the region too.

Cricket came to India with the British in the 19th century and became an absolute and lasting passion.



A MONUMENT TO LOVE

India's most famous building, and perhaps one of the most beautiful in the world, is the Taj Mahal. It was built by Emperor Shah Jahan in memory of his second wife. The structure was finally completed in 1653, having taken 20,000 craftsmen and builders over 20 years to build.

ARABIC ARTS

Islam forbids the depiction of God or of the human form, but Arabic buildings and artefacts are far from plain. They are decorated, instead, with geometric shapes or with curvaceous Arabic script—an exquisite art form in itself.



MAGIC CARPETS

Wonderful rugs and carpets are produced, often by hand, throughout central Asia. Beautiful as well as durable, they often function as family heirlooms or substitute for savings accounts, in the way that jewelry sometimes does in the West.



BOLLYWOOD

The Bollywood film industry, based in Mumbai (Bombay), is the biggest in the world, producing over 800 films a year.



MIND AND BODY

The discipline of yoga, which consists of exercises good for both physical and mental well-being, originated in India centuries ago.

